# Building Systems That Work

Product, Project & Process Strategy

ENGL 46602/56602: Project Management for Writers | Purdue University Fort Wayne

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*This curriculum teaches students to think like product and project managers, not by making them PMs, but by giving them the frameworks, vocabulary, and practice to lead complex writing and communication projects from discovery through delivery. It is designed for writers, content strategists, and communicators entering cross-functional industry roles.*

## Curriculum Overview

This 9-week (or 15-week) assignment sequence teaches the full product and project strategy lifecycle: from user research and vision-setting through backlog management, roadmap planning, metrics design, and portfolio-ready case study synthesis.

> **CORE LEARNING OUTCOMES:** Students completing this sequence will be able to: (1) conduct lightweight user research and translate findings into a product vision; (2) write and prioritize user stories in an Agile framework; (3) build and communicate a product roadmap; (4) define meaningful success metrics; and (5) synthesize their work into a portfolio case study.

> **WHY THIS MATTERS FOR WRITERS:** Content strategists, UX writers, and technical communicators increasingly work on cross-functional product teams. Understanding PM frameworks — user stories, backlogs, roadmaps, OKRs — is essential to participating meaningfully in those teams. This curriculum gives writers the literacy to collaborate with PMs without becoming PMs.

### Two Versions of This Curriculum

- 400/500-Level (9 weeks): Students build a product strategy from scratch, including original user research and a complete 0→1 case study.
- 300-Level (15 weeks): Students receive a pre-defined product prompt and focus on refinement, prioritization, and planning rather than invention.

# Part 1: Full Assignment Sequence (400/500-Level)

*9-week sequence. Students build a complete product strategy from discovery through portfolio synthesis.*

## Stage 1 Product Strategy & Discovery (Weeks 1–3)

*Goal: Develop an aligned product strategy that addresses user needs and business goals.*

Students begin by conducting primary user research through stakeholder interviews, either with real stakeholders or peers role-playing cofounders, users, or other relevant personas. They then conduct lightweight market and competitive research to identify positioning opportunities.

- Conduct 2–3 stakeholder interviews using a prepared interview guide.
- Synthesize findings into 2–3 key user problems with supporting evidence.
- Draft a 1-page Product Strategy Brief including: vision statement, key user problems, differentiators, and high-level success metrics.
- Develop 2–3 user personas with goals, pain points, and relevant behaviors.
- Map at least one user journey from awareness through task completion.

> 📌 **INSTRUCTOR NOTE:** *The 1-page constraint on the strategy brief is intentional and important. Students who cannot distill their strategy to one page have not yet achieved clarity. Push back on any brief that exceeds the limit, I require them to revise and prioritize.*

DELIVERABLE

**Deliverable 1**

1-page Product Strategy Brief + 2–3 personas and user journeys

## Stage 2 Technical Planning & Agile Execution (Weeks 4–6)

*Goal: Translate strategy into implementable tasks using Agile frameworks.*

Students learn the core Agile vocabulary and workflow: epics, user stories, acceptance criteria, story points, sprints, backlogs, stand-ups, and retrospectives. They practice in low-stakes mock environments using Trello or Jira (or low-fi equivalent on LMS Brightspace).

- Break the product vision into 3–5 epics (major feature areas).
- Write 8–12 user stories from the personas developed in Stage 1.
- Prioritize the backlog using a simple value/effort matrix.
- Build a 2-week sprint plan in Trello or Jira, including task definitions and acceptance criteria.
- Facilitate a 5-minute mock daily stand-up with your team.
- Conduct a sprint review and retrospective: what went well, what would you change?

> 📌 **INSTRUCTOR NOTE:** *The stand-up exercise is one of the most valuable in this sequence. Many students have never facilitated a structured team check-in. Even 5 minutes of practice — what did I do, what will I do, what's blocking me — changes how they think about project communication.*

> **USER STORY FORMAT:** As a [user type], I want to [action] so that [benefit]. Every story must have acceptance criteria: the conditions under which the story is considered done.

DELIVERABLE

**Deliverable 2**

Sprint plan: Trello/Jira board screenshot + task definitions + backlog rationale (300–500 words explaining prioritization decisions)

## Stage 3 Roadmap & Metrics (Weeks 7–8)

*Goal: Plan long-term delivery and define what success looks like.*

Students build a quarterly product roadmap that balances user impact against technical capacity and business constraints. They also design a metrics framework that defines how success will be measured for each major feature.

- Build a quarterly roadmap (3–4 months) in Productboard style, Canva, or PowerPoint.
- Organize roadmap by theme or feature area, not just by time.
- For each major feature, define: one primary success metric, one secondary metric, and one guardrail metric.
- Design an A/B test plan for one key feature: hypothesis, variants, measurement approach, and success threshold.

> 📌 **INSTRUCTOR NOTE:** *The distinction between primary, secondary, and guardrail metrics is a genuine PM concept that changes how students think about measurement. A guardrail metric is one that must not get worse as you optimize for the primary metric. This prevents optimization failures where you improve one thing at the cost of something important.*

> **METRIC TYPES:** Primary metric: what you're optimizing for. Secondary metric: what you're also tracking. Guardrail metric: what must not decline. Example for an onboarding feature: Primary = Day-7 retention. Secondary = Onboarding completion rate. Guardrail = Support ticket volume.

DELIVERABLE

**Deliverable 3**

Visual roadmap (Productboard/Canva/PowerPoint style) + metrics tracking framework with primary, secondary, and guardrail metrics defined

## Stage 4 Portfolio Synthesis (Week 9)

*Goal: Package all artifacts into a polished, portfolio-ready case study.*

Students integrate all deliverables into a coherent case study that tells the story of their product from discovery through strategy. The case study is structured to be shared with potential employers as evidence of PM-adjacent thinking and strategic communication.

- Write a 500–750 word narrative framing the case study: what problem did you solve, what tradeoffs did you make, what would you do differently?
- Compile and polish all artifacts: user research → strategy brief → personas → backlog → sprint board → roadmap → metrics plan.
- Present as if reporting to cofounders and a CTO: confident, evidence-based, ready for hard questions.
- Prepare for 3–5 questions from the audience about your prioritization decisions.

> 📌 **INSTRUCTOR NOTE:** *The presentation framing matters. Students who present as if they're reporting to authority figures perform differently than students presenting as experts. Frame this explicitly: you are the person who did the research. You know more about this product than anyone in the room. Present from that position.*

DELIVERABLE

**Final Deliverable**

Portfolio-ready '0–1 Product Strategy Case Study' — includes: product vision, user research synthesis, personas, strategy brief, backlog, sprint board, roadmap, metrics framework, and tradeoff reflection

# Part 2: 300-Level Version (15-Week Semester)

*Scaled for students new to product thinking. Pre-defined product prompt. Focus on refinement, prioritization, and planning rather than invention.*

## Four Scaling Decisions

1. Narrow the scope. Give students a pre-defined product prompt (e.g., 'a wellness app for college students') and 2–3 user profiles. Their job is to refine, prioritize, and plan — not invent everything.
2. Chunk the deliverables. Each stage becomes a small graded assignment leading to a final case study. No single high-stakes deliverable.
3. Use familiar tools. Trello for 'Jira boards.' Google Sheets or Airtable for metrics. Canva or PowerPoint for roadmaps.
4. Frame as literacy, not mastery. The goal is learning the thinking, not becoming a PM. Rubrics emphasize clarity and rationale, not technical PM precision.

> 📌 **INSTRUCTOR NOTE:** *The most important framing decision in this curriculum: 'We are not training PMs. We are training people who can work with PMs.' Students relax when they understand this distinction. They stop trying to be perfect and start trying to be clear.*

## 15-Week Sequence

### Weeks 1–2: Orientation & Product Strategy Foundations

- Introduce product strategy & PM basics (vision, user needs, business alignment).
- Provide the product prompt — students will not create from scratch.
- Students develop a 1-page Product Vision Statement.

**Deliverable:** Product Vision Statement + 2–3 bullet success metrics

### Weeks 3–5: User Needs & Early Planning

- Teach user journeys, personas, and basic research.
- Students draft a simple user journey map and refine product vision.
- Begin breaking down features into user stories.

**Deliverable:** User Journey Map + prioritized list of 6–8 user stories

### Weeks 6–8: Backlog & Agile Framework

- Introduce Agile, sprints, and backlog management.
- Students create a mock backlog and plan a 2-week sprint in Trello.
- Run mini stand-ups (5 minutes): practice facilitation and communication.

**Deliverable:** Sprint Backlog (Trello screenshot + backlog rationale)

### Weeks 9–11: Roadmap & Metrics

- Teach roadmap planning and prioritization frameworks.
- Students draft a quarterly roadmap (3–4 features).
- Develop a metrics dashboard mock-up: what will they measure and why?

**Deliverable:** Quarterly Roadmap + Metrics Framework (3 metrics minimum)

### Weeks 12–14: Refinement & Reflection

- Integrate all deliverables into a single case study format.
- Include a brief tradeoff reflection: What changed? What was hardest?
- Optional: practice presenting the case to 'stakeholders.'

**Deliverable:** Draft case study with tradeoff reflection

### Week 15: Final Presentations & Portfolio Packaging

- Students present case studies (5–7 minutes).

- Provide guidance on how to export artifacts for portfolios.
- Peer feedback: what is clear, what needs more support?

**Deliverable:** Portfolio-ready 'Product & Process Strategy Case Study' including: product vision, user journey, backlog, roadmap, metrics, reflection

> 📌 **INSTRUCTOR NOTE:** *Portfolio packaging is often skipped in academic courses but is one of the most useful things you can teach. A student who can export a Trello board as a PDF, annotate it with context, and assemble it into a coherent case study document is ready for a PM-adjacent job interview. Spend 20–30 minutes of Week 15 on this specifically.*

# Part 3: Tools, Templates & Rubric Guidance

## Recommended Tools by Stage

| Stage | Tool | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| **User Research** | Google Forms / Docs | Interview guides, synthesis templates. Low friction. |
| **Strategy Brief** | Google Docs / Word | 1-page constraint is a design decision. Enforce it. |
| **Personas** | Canva / Google Slides | Visual format encourages specificity over abstraction. |
| **User Journey Map** | Miro / FigJam / Canva | Miro free tier is sufficient. Use sticky notes for low-fi. |
| **Backlog & Sprint** | Trello | More intuitive than Jira for first-timers. Free. |
| **Roadmap** | Canva / PowerPoint / Google Slides | The visual format matters — enforce a quarterly view. |
| **Metrics Framework** | Google Sheets / Airtable | Simple 3-column table: metric, definition, target. |
| **Case Study** | Notion / Google Docs / Word | Notion is ideal for portfolio assembly and sharing. |

## Rubric Philosophy

Rubrics for this curriculum should emphasize clarity and rationale over technical PM precision. Students are writers learning to think strategically—not PMs learning to write.

- Clarity: Can the reader understand exactly what the student is proposing, measuring, or deciding?
- Rationale: Does the student explain why they made the decisions they made?
- Evidence: Are decisions grounded in user research, not assumptions?
- Coherence: Do the deliverables tell a connected story from discovery through delivery?
- Craft: Is the writing professional, specific, and free of vague language?

> **WHAT NOT TO GRADE:** Technical PM vocabulary for its own sake. Perfect Jira/Trello setup. Whether the product is a 'good idea.' The grade should reflect whether the student can think clearly about strategy, communicate decisions, and build on evidence.

> 📌 **INSTRUCTOR NOTE:** *The most common student failure mode in this curriculum is vagueness. 'We will improve user engagement' is not a metric. 'We will increase Day-7 retention from 40% to 55% within two sprint cycles' is a metric. Push students toward specificity at every stage. Vagueness is not humility; it is avoidance.*


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